



growth of the sport. It's an exciting time for chess in India.

How do you evaluate your performance this year?

I've had some strong tournaments this year. My rating reached 2762, and I was ranked World No. 7. However, I had a poor result at the Biel Chess Festival, which cost me some Elo points.

Still, I believe my game is improving, and that's what matters. I performed well at Norway Chess, finishing third. There have been some lows in between, but I just need to focus on becoming more consistent.

Dutch Grandmaster Anish Giri mentioned the concept of 'mental injury' in chess. What are your thoughts on mental exhaustion affecting players?

Yes, it's definitely an issue, especially when you're playing

back-to-back events. You can burn out and feel the need for a break. But the tournaments keep coming. Sometimes, you lose motivation to play your best. The mental aspect of chess is crucial. We often talk about physical injuries, but I think mental exhaustion can be just as impactful — it's like a form of injury in chess.

What's your take on changes in time control with every new tournament?

I like new ideas, but I feel time control is one thing where they could have found one and tried to keep it fixed at least for some official events. It is important because we are playing too many tournaments now, and with each tournament, the time control changes.

Does the financial aspect of chess motivate you, or is it secondary to your passion for the game?

I don't think the financial side

Stirring effort: Grandmaster R. Praggnanandhaa contributed significantly to India's gold medal in the Open section at the Chess Olympiad in Hungary, scoring 6/10 on the second board. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

motivates me. My focus is purely on playing my best games and improving my ranking. Right now, I'm driven by the goal of increasing my rating. I don't really think about money; my parents handle that. I play chess because I love it and want to achieve something meaningful.

How does travelling with your family, particularly your mother and sister, impact your preparation and performance?

When my mother travels with me, she takes care of my meals and helps me bounce back when I'm feeling down. When I'm alone, I have to manage these things myself. As for my sister, I've played enough